

Your Housing Options

Looking for your first apartment or upgrading to a better one? Take a few minutes to think about what's important to you in your living space, such as access to public transportation or being able to own pets. Identify the things you won't compromise on. This will help you quickly rule out places that don't meet your minimum standards. If you can't find a suitable apartment in your price range, consider sharing a house or apartment with a roommate, or renting a studio or efficiency apartment.



You'll need to have two months' rent saved up before you rent an apartment: one month's worth for the security deposit, plus the first month's rent. Some landlords require that you also pay the last month's rent up front, for a total of three months' worth of rent.

How Much Rent You Can Afford

As a general rule of thumb, allow no more than 30 percent of your gross income for housing. If you're making \$35,000 a year, you shouldn't pay more than \$875 a month for rent. You'd be more comfortable at 25 percent, or \$729 a month. If some or all of the utilities are included, you could pay higher rent.